

generations of copies would there have been between MS 18 and the family archetype? Might there have been fifteen, or more? I would imagine that there were at least ten. However many there actually were, please note that every last one of them was perfect! *The implications of finding a perfect representative of any archetypal text are rather powerful. All the 'canons' of textual criticism become irrelevant to any point subsequent to the creation of that text* (they could still come into play when studying the creation of the text, in the event). For MS 18 to be perfect, all the generations in between had to be perfect as well. Now I call this **incredibly careful transmission**. Nothing that I was taught in Seminary about New Testament textual criticism prepared me for this discovery! Nor anything that I had read, for that matter. But MS 18 is not an isolated case; all the thirty-four MSS in the chart above reflect an **incredibly careful transmission**—even the worst of the lot, minuscules 1761 and 1874, with their seven variants [the ‘singulars’ in 1893 and 1248 are careless mistakes {unhappy monks}], are really quite good, considering all the intervening generations.

This point deserves some elaboration. A typical ‘Alexandrian’ MS will have over a dozen variants per page of printed Greek text. A typical ‘Byzantine’ MS will have 3-5 variants per page. MSS 1761 and 1876 have about one per page, and one of the better f^{35} MSS will go for pages without a variant. There is an obvious difference in the mentality that the monks brought to their task. A monk copying an ‘Alexandrian’ MS evidently did not consider that he was handling Scripture, in stark contrast to one copying an f^{35} MS. For those who do not exclude the supernatural from their model, I submit that the information above is highly significant: obviously God was not protecting any ‘Alexandrian’ type of MS, probably because it contained ‘tares’ (Matthew 13:28). A monk copying a ‘Byzantine’ bulk type MS did far better work than the Alexandrian, but still was not being sufficiently careful—he was probably just doing a religious duty, but without personal commitment to the Text. Since God respects our choices (John 4:23-24), the result was a typical ‘Byzantine’ MS. It is also true that not all f^{35} MSS were carefully done, but I conclude that the core representatives were done by copyists who believed they were handling God’s Word and wanted their work to be pleasing to Him¹—just the kind that the Holy Spirit would delight to aid and protect.

¹ It is not at all uncommon to find a colophon at the end of a MS where the copyist calls on God for His mercy, and even for His recognition and blessing.